Does Malta have Europe's highest density of hunters?

Testing a news report's claim about hunter density against FACE's country table and Eurostat

THE CLAIM UNDER REVIEW

"Malta has the highest density of hunters in all of Europe."

Mongabay (Spoorthy Raman), 5 October 2026.
The outlet's own sentence, linking to a 2015 paper.

VERDICT: LARGELY SUPPORTED

True per area; not per inhabitant

Version 1.0 · 28 October 2026
Status: no right of reply needed
Prepared from public sources, FACE and Eurostat data.
Repository: github.com/leandergrech/Mizien

TL;DR

Mongabay's news report of 5 October 2026 on the shooting of migratory birds after the storm of 14 September says, in its own voice: **"Malta has the highest density of hunters in all of Europe."** The sentence does not say what the density is measured against. We recomputed it from the only country-by-country table we could open, the European hunters' federation FACE's 2009–2010 table (35 countries), and from Eurostat's land area and population. Per square kilometre Malta is first by a wide margin; per head of population it is not.

1. **Per square kilometre, the claim holds.** Malta had 47 hunters per km² on FACE's count of 15,000 (Eurostat area 316 km²), 9.5 times the next country, Ireland (5.0). It stays first even at 10,000 hunters (32 per km²) and would at 5,000 (16 per km²).
2. **Per head of population, it does not.** On the same table Malta is 5th of 35 (36 per 1,000 inhabitants), behind Ireland (83), Finland (59), Cyprus (56) and Norway (40). With about 10,000 hunters and today's population it is 18 per 1,000.
3. **The sentence does not say which.** 'Density' most naturally means per area, which is the reading the evidence supports; a reader could also take it as hunters per inhabitant.
4. **The numbers are old or second-hand.** FACE's table is from 2009–2010. No current official count was readable: the Wild Birds Regulation Unit's reports are browser-only. The 10,000 figure is BirdLife Malta's, as quoted by Mongabay.
5. **Verdict: largely supported (moderate confidence).** True on the usual meaning of density and robust to the uncertainty in Malta's count; not true per capita, which the sentence does not exclude.



47
Malta hunters per km² (FACE count 15,000; area 316 km²). Next highest: Ireland, 5.0

9.5×
Malta's density as a multiple of the next country's, FACE 2009–10 table

5th
Malta's rank of 35 per 1,000 inhabitants, same table (Ireland 1st)

32
Malta hunters per km² at 10,000 hunters (BirdLife Malta via Mongabay)

WHAT WOULD MOVE THE VERDICT UP
A current official count of Malta's hunters and a current country-by-country table for Europe showing the same ranking per km²; or the cited paper stating the ranking and its basis.

WHAT WOULD MOVE IT DOWN
A current, comparable count showing another country (or a small state we could not rank) above Malta per km², or evidence that the sentence was meant per inhabitant.

IN THIS REPORT

1 The claim and what we could verify
2 Method
3 What the data show
4 Where the evidence points different ways
5 Testing the claim
6 Verdict and requests for evidence
7 Limitations

1 The claim and what we could verify

The claim is a sentence in a short news report by Spoorthy Raman, published by Mongabay on 5 October 2026 [1], which we read in full. It is the outlet's own sentence, not a quotation from BirdLife Malta or any official; it links to a 2015 paper in *Biological Conservation*. The next sentence is a quotation from Antonia Micallef of BirdLife Malta, who is quoted as saying "Over 10,000 hunters [are] active at any one time." The check is of the density ranking only.

What was said	Who	Access
"Malta has the highest density of hunters in all of Europe."	Mongabay (outlet's own words) [1]	Read in full
"Over 10,000 hunters [are] active at any one time"	A. Micallef, BirdLife Malta, quoted by Mongabay [1]	Read in full
Linked source: Veríssimo D., Campbell B. (2015), *Biological Conservation*, doi:10.1016/j.biocon.2015.07.018	Linked by Mongabay [2]	Identity verified in Crossref; closed access, abstract not available, not read

SCOPE NOTE
This check covers the density ranking only. It makes no statement about hunters as people, about the legality of any shooting reported in the article, or about the incident figures attributed to BirdLife Malta.

2 Method

Question. Is Malta's density of hunters the highest in Europe, and does the answer depend on what density is measured against?

Evidence. FACE's table 'Hunters in Europe' (35 countries with a count; area, population and hunters) from its Annual Report 2009–2010 [3]; Eurostat population on 1 January and land area for Malta [4]; Malta hunter counts from FACE [3] and, for sensitivity, the 10,000 figure quoted by Mongabay [1] and a licence count from the Wild Birds Regulation Unit (WBRU) known to us only second-hand (◆) [5]. All numbers are recomputed by *tools/cc-144-report/calc.py* from files in *data/cc-144/*. For Malta we use Eurostat's area and population rather than FACE's rounded 0.3 thousand km² and 0.4 million; for other countries we use FACE's own area and population, which are rounded to the nearest thousand km² or 0.1 million.

Grades. Official statistics and the federation's own table are grade C; the NGO's count is grade D (assertion). **Verdicts** follow the five-point scale in Appendix A.

3 What the data show

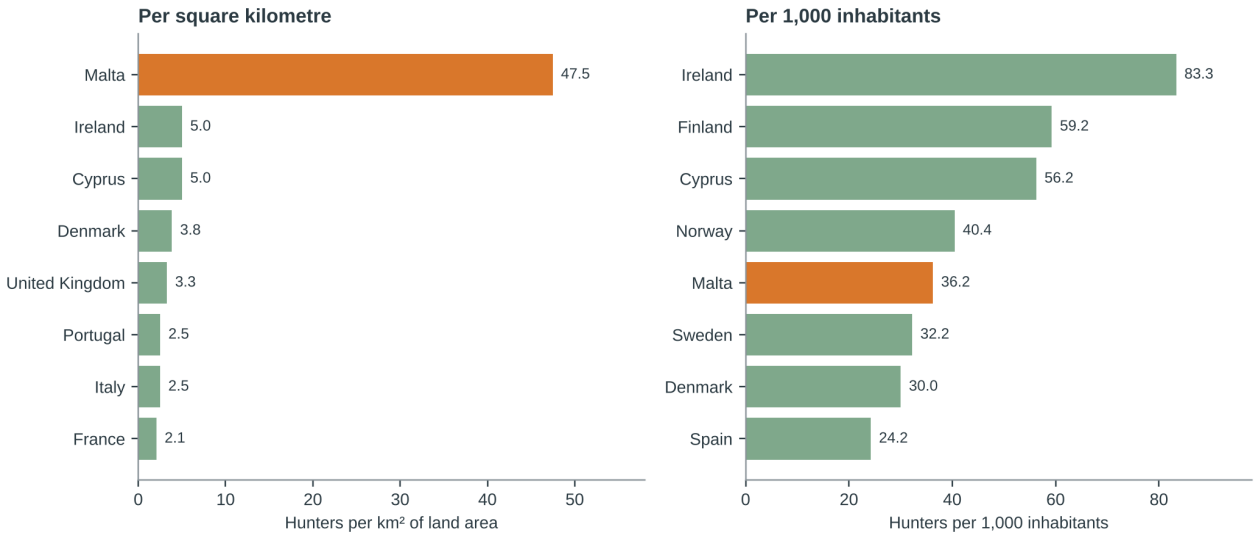


Figure 1. Hunters per km² (left) and per 1,000 inhabitants (right), top countries in FACE's 2009–2010 table; Malta in orange. Malta leads per km² and is fifth per head.

Indicator	Malta	Comparison	Source	Grade
Hunters per km², FACE count 15,000	**47.5** (1st of 35)	Ireland 5.0, Cyprus 5.0, Denmark 3.8	FACE [3]; Eurostat [4]	C
Malta as multiple of next highest	**9.5×**	Ireland	calculated	C
Hunters per km² at 10,000 hunters	31.6	6.3× Ireland	Mongabay [1]; Eurostat [4]	D
Hunters per km² at 5,000 (stress test)	15.8	3.2× Ireland	calculated	C
Hunters per 1,000 inhabitants, FACE count	36.2 (**5th** of 35)	Ireland 83.3, Finland 59.2, Cyprus 56.2, Norway 40.4	FACE [3]; Eurostat [4]	C
Hunters per 1,000 at 10,000 hunters, 2024 population	17.7	10 other countries' 2010 values higher	Mongabay [1]; Eurostat [4]	D
Population growth 2010–2024	+36%	Eurostat	demo_pjan [4]	C

All values in data/cc-144/checks.csv and ranking_2010.csv. FACE's counts are 2009–2010; the comparison with Malta's current numbers therefore mixes years and is indicative only.

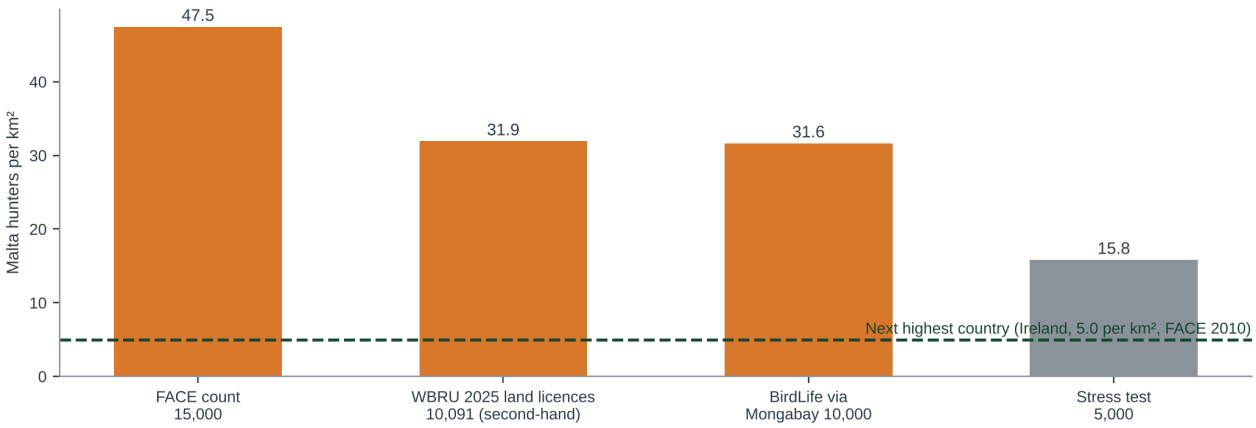


Figure 2. Malta's hunters per km² under four counts, against the next-highest country in FACE's table. The ranking per km² survives a two-thirds cut in Malta's count.

Malta's area (316 km²) is small and its population density is among the highest in the world, so any per-area count of a population-linked activity gives a high figure. That is a fact about the denominator, not about hunting: it is why the per-area and per-head rankings differ.

4 Where the evidence points different ways

Q1 Is Malta first in Europe for hunters per area? — YES, BY A WIDE MARGIN

EVIDENCE FOR THE CLAIM'S IMPRESSION

On FACE's table Malta has 47.5 hunters per km², 9.5 times Ireland and Cyprus (5.0 each). Even with Malta's count cut to a third (5,000) it stays first (15.8 per km²).

EVIDENCE AGAINST

FACE's other countries' areas are rounded to thousand km², so small states (Luxembourg, Cyprus) carry large rounding errors, and no 2026 table was readable. Microstates absent from the table (for example San Marino, Liechtenstein) are not tested.

WHY THEY DIFFER, AND WHAT IT MEANS HERE

For this claim: on the usual reading (per area) it is supported with a large margin; the uncertainty in the year and the count would have to be several-fold to change the ranking.

Q2 Is Malta first for hunters per inhabitant? — NO

EVIDENCE FOR THE CLAIM'S IMPRESSION

Malta's 36 hunters per 1,000 inhabitants (FACE count, 2010 population) is high, fifth of 35.

EVIDENCE AGAINST

Ireland (83), Finland (59), Cyprus (56) and Norway (40) are higher on the same table. A second-hand 2018 chart (Statista, citing the German Hunting Association ◆) also puts Ireland, Finland and Cyprus ahead and does not list Malta. At 10,000 hunters Malta is at 18 per 1,000.

WHY THEY DIFFER, AND WHAT IT MEANS HERE

For this claim: if 'density' were read per inhabitant, the claim would be contradicted by the same table. The sentence does not specify; we treat per area as the primary meaning of 'density'.

Q3 How many hunters does Malta have now? NOT KNOWN FROM A CURRENT OFFICIAL SOURCE

EVIDENCE FOR THE CLAIM'S IMPRESSION

BirdLife Malta, quoted by Mongabay, says over 10,000 are active at any one time. A search summary of the WBRU 2025 report gave 10,091 general licences for hunting birds on land ◆ (not opened).

EVIDENCE AGAINST

FACE's 2009–2010 count is 15,000. BirdLife Malta has said elsewhere that WBRU has not published a total number of hunting licences (reported in a search summary ◆, not verified by us). Licensees may hold several licence categories.

WHY THEY DIFFER, AND WHAT IT MEANS HERE

For this claim: the count matters less than the denominator, because every plausible count (5,000–15,000) keeps Malta first per km².

5 Testing the claim

Sub-claim	What the evidence shows	Rating
A. "Malta has the highest density of hunters in all of Europe", read per area	47.5 per km² on FACE's count, 9.5× the next country; first at every count from 5,000 to 15,000 [3][4].	SUPPORTED
B. The same sentence read per inhabitant	Fifth of 35 on FACE's table (36 per 1,000; Ireland 83); 18 per 1,000 at 10,000 hunters [3][4].	NOT FIRST
C. "Over 10,000 hunters [are] active at any one time" (BirdLife Malta, quoted)	Consistent in order of magnitude with FACE (15,000) and the WBRU licence count ◆ (10,091); no current official total read. Not a claim about density; context only.	NOT RATED

6 Verdict and requests for evidence

VERDICT

LARGELY SUPPORTED

True per area, by a wide margin; not true per inhabitant, which the sentence does not exclude. Confidence: moderate.

Why. (1) 'Density' without qualification most naturally means per unit area, and on that measure FACE's own table puts Malta first by a factor of 9.5, a margin that survives a two-thirds reduction in Malta's count. (2) The same table ranks Malta fifth per inhabitant. A reader who takes density per head would be misled, so the claim is not 'Supported' outright. (3) The comparison table is from 2009–2010 and the current Malta count is NGO-sourced or second-hand, which limits confidence to moderate.

What this verdict does not say. It does not say that the number of hunters is high or low in absolute terms, that hunting in Malta is lawful or unlawful, or anything about any person.

Evidence we are asking for

- ☐ The WBRU's current total of licensed hunters (all categories, de-duplicated by person).
- ☐ A current FACE or national country-by-country table of hunter numbers.
- ☐ The basis of the claim in the 2015 paper linked by Mongabay (full text).

7 Limitations

- The only country-by-country table we could open is FACE's 2009–2010 table; its definition of 'hunter' (licence holders, or active hunters) may differ by country, and FACE itself rounds areas and populations.
- A 2023 FACE activity report was searched for country figures and held none; FACE's current member-country statistics were not found. A search was also run for a more recent table (28 Oct 2026); only a 2018 Statista chart (second-hand ◆) and a paywalled 2025 count for seven countries were found.
- wbru.gov.mt returned HTTP 403 to scripts, so the WBRU 2024 and 2025 Game Reporting Data reports were not opened; the 10,091 figure is from a search summary and is marked ◆.
- The 2015 paper linked by Mongabay is closed access and no abstract was available; we did not read what it says about Malta.
- Microstates not in the FACE table were not tested.
- Mixing 2009–2010 counts for other countries with Malta's current numbers is indicative only.

References

[1] Raman S. (5 Oct 2026). Hunters reportedly kill hundreds of migratory birds stranded by thunderstorm in Malta. *Mongabay*. https://news.mongabay.com/short-article/2026/10/hunters-reportedly-kill-hundreds-of-migratory-birds-stranded-by-thunderstorm-in-malta/

[2] Veríssimo D., Campbell B. (2015). Understanding stakeholder conflict between conservation and hunting in Malta. *Biological Conservation*. doi:10.1016/j.biocon.2015.07.018. (Identity verified in Crossref; not read.) https://doi.org/10.1016/j.biocon.2015.07.018

[3] FACE (2010). Annual Report 2009–2010, p. 16: 'Hunters in Europe' (table of area, hunters, population by country). Retrieved 28 Oct 2026. https://www.face.eu/sites/default/files/attachments/data_hunters-region_sept_2010.pdf

[4] Eurostat. demo_pjan (population on 1 January: 2010, 2024, 2025) and demo_r_d3area (area, Malta); retrieved 28 Oct 2026. https://ec.europa.eu/eurostat/databrowser/

[5] ◆ Wild Birds Regulation Unit (2026). Game Reporting Data report 2025. Known only from a search summary; the site returned HTTP 403. https://wbru.gov.mt/wp-content/uploads/2026/07/Game-Reporting-Data-report-2025.pdf

[6] Miżien. Data and calculations: data/cc-144/; tools/cc-144-report/calc.py.

Appendix A: series standards and verdict scale

Every investigation in this series follows the same rules so that verdicts are comparable and challengeable.

Verdict	Meaning
SUPPORTED	Evidence consistently backs the claim as stated.
LARGELY SUPPORTED	Backed by the evidence, with minor caveats that do not change the substance.
NOT SUBSTANTIATED	Stated more strongly than the evidence offered or available allows. May be true in some conditions but has not been shown.
MISLEADING	Omits material facts so that the overall impression is inaccurate, even if individual statements are defensible.
CONTRADICTED	The available evidence points against the claim.

Confidence

High: multiple independent lines of evidence agree. **Moderate**: evidence is relevant but incomplete or indirect. **Low**: evidence is thin, second-hand or conflicting.

Evidence grades

A experiment · B observational study with a control or gradient · C review, guidance or official statistics · D assertion or anecdote. ◆ marks a source known only second-hand.

Standards

- **Quote the speaker, not the headline,** with outlet and date, and link the original where possible.
- **Separate the claim from the evidence offered for it,** and say who made which statement.
- **Grade the evidence** and show differing views side by side where the evidence is unsettled.
- **State what we could not access or verify,** and what would change the verdict either way.
- **Ask for the missing evidence** in specific, answerable requests.
- **Offer a right of reply** where a check finds a claim Not substantiated, Misleading or Contradicted (or a pledge Not measurable, Off track or Missed), before wider circulation, and append responses.
- **Correct errors openly** with a version number and change log.
- **Whistle-blow only on evidence:** a verdict of *Misleading* or *Contradicted* requires documents or data that can be shown, not inference.
- **Check every side.** Government, opposition, NGOs and developers are held to the same standard.

Appendix B: revision log

Version	Date	Change
1.0	28 Oct 2026	First issue.